

Topic: Effectiveness of Persuasive Speech On the Audience About the Israel-Hamas War

Research Question: How do Ursula von der Leyen and Joe Biden use exigency to effectively inform and appeal to the audience about the Israel-Hamas War?

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Introduction

A speaker's political exigency and its emotional appeal to the target audience often undergo an interplay of verbal and visual communication. According to Erik Juergensmeyer, an English professor from Lewis College, the Rogerian theory argues that communication is mostly effective when limited invention strategies do not lead to individual isolation (10). In order to successfully transmit one's ideas, beliefs, and arguments, both parties must be individually willing to listen to challenging views, else there would be no collaborative, intellectual environment. Besides, the conditions and background of the listener also drastically impact their actions and ideologies depending on their emotional responsiveness; the more personal the discussion, the more predisposed they are to concede with statements that resonate with their social difficulties. Thus, it is more effective to refine the use of pathos in a speech than any other emotional appeal, being one of the most relevant modes of persuasion during conflicting matters. Having an intimate connection with the audience and making references to their individual context facilitates the delivery of the given message, potentially leading to a better rhetorical reception and commitment to the solution. However, when an audience is diverse, complicated, and unpredictable, the speaker is responsible for familiarizing themselves beforehand in order to tailor the speech to the listeners' respective circumstances. To do so, they implement a wide range of rhetorical strategies to move both specific minorities and large groups of people, which may meet distinctive expectations in other regions. In sum, a speech is effective mainly when the targeted audience can understand and connect with the speaker's exigency, given its contextual and personal relevance with their lives, environment, relationships, and demographics. Beyond political compliance, the speaker's intention may be to mitigate conflict, reach an agreement, and prompt a call-to-action towards a problem that is in dire need of being resolved, argued, and

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reformed. Similarly, manipulating language, reception of voice, physical appearance, and first impressions, is just as important to enable trust from the speaker's knowledge because it evokes a more powerful speech.

Understanding the context behind each speech is not only vital to measure its personal connection to the audience, but the efficacy in which the speaker addresses the problem. The Arab-Israeli conflict, spurring on May 1948, was the product of political fear, territorial dispossession, and the Zionist settlement of Jewish people into Jerusalem, Israel. As the Office of the Historian proclaims, the war “broke out when five Arab nations invaded territory in the former Palestinian mandate immediately following the announcement of the independence of the state of Israel.” Furthermore, the United States recognized the independence of the state of Israel, but maintained an arms embargo, restricting the access and export of military equipment for warfare use. During this time, the United States supported the United Nations General Assembly resolution— which was to divide Great Britain's former Palestinian mandate into Jewish and Arab states— while also encouraging negotiations in the Middle East. Although the United Nations managed two cease-fires during the war until 1949, there were no official armistice agreements between Israelian, Arabian, and Palestinian states, leaving a belligerent mark in their relations and an unresolved tension over the surrender of West Bank and Gaza Strip territories. In May 1967, Jordan and Egypt signed the Six-Day War with Israel and some Arab states, holding armistice lines by delineating the Green Line, a division which separated Arab and Israel-controlled territories from one another. Amidst all the casualties, the United States refrained from getting involved to prevent the instability in the Middle East from interfering with the Soviet Union and the United States itself.

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By taking this historical record into consideration, it then leads to the research question: *How do Ursula von der Leyen and Joe Biden use exigency to effectively inform and appeal to the audience about the Israel-Hamas War?* For the entirety of the paper, this question will explore beyond rhetorical situations, including the effect and function of a political speech and indicators of emotional appeal on the audience through intentional authorial choices provided by the context. In response to the Israel-Hamas war stirring on October 7, 2023, President Joe Biden gave a speech on October 10, 2023, while President Von der Leyen spoke on October 18, 2023 on the same issue regarding horrors of the mass killings in Israel. Both of these leaders express their exigency to the audience in order to inform, appeal, and reach an unanimous conclusion. Depending on the implementation of their techniques and effect on personal engagement, it determines how effective their preposition in favor of Israel's defense against Hamas' terrorism, sway the target audience into a virtuous course of action.

President Ursula Von der Leyen's Speech

On October 18, 2023, In the Louise Weiss building, Strasbourg, France, Ursula Von der Leyen held a speech for the European Parliament debate, a democratic electorate of Europe. This occurred eleven days after the Israel-Hamas attack, where a cabinet of 27 member states delivered contrasting solutions to each other, based on Joyner, a Brussels correspondent of the EU issues. As to date, Von der Leyen is the 13th President of the European Commissioner, a member of the Christian Democratic Union of Germany, and affiliated with the European People's Party, a European political party. After the debate, Yahya Synwar, one of the commanders of the Israel-Hamas attack who led from 2017 to 2024, died on October 16, 2024 after an airstrike targeting his home. Listed as an EU terrorist, Synwar was described as an

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insurmountable obstacle from rebuilding the state and providing aid to Israel, by Borrell.

Likewise, the militant group Hamas was classified as a terrorist organization due to its violation of the international humanitarian law, including mass violence and immoral actions. Their involvement during the war might have fortified Von der Leyen and the committee's exigency on holding the debate, considering how they came across multiple third parties that hindered Israeli relief. Von der Leyen's separate stance in the Israeli Defense Force military (IDF) proved that the bloc's dilemma on providing military support to Israel, may have raised national concerns regarding their humanitarian mission and the ways they were doing so.

Von der Leyen gave a speech inside the Louise Weiss building to more than 705 representatives and members. She appeared wearing a blue, formal suit corresponding to the professional environment, standing in front of a row of podiums and the EU flag. At first glance, there seems to be an occasional association between the tone of the speaker and the complementary colors such as blue, yellow and white. Blue can be found within each podium; yellow, mostly in the stars of the EU flag and facial appearance, and white slightly in the vest. This combination of solid, neutral colors communicates a sense of intellectuality and presentability both in the formal setting and in the gravity of the situation (Calvin University). While blue is often associated with authenticity and trust, yellow alludes to the Alliance of Liberals and Democrats for Europe Party, an ideology that the European Parliament coincides with. Together with yellow, the opposite colors equal out, representing the European Parliament being in a state of power, justice, and control. Since there are rarely any distracting colors, the audience would be more inclined to listen to Von der Leyen's claims and her composed body language. While soft, bland colors appeal to a sense of transparency, Von der Leyen manages to inform the audience by reminding them of their position of authority in the executive Louise

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Weiss building. She surrounds herself with a stagnant setting to, not only emit a tense atmosphere, but also establish the political meaning behind the EU Parliament's mission. By participating in the debate, Von der Leyen communicates her exigency effectively to the audience given the context of the organization's diplomatic relations, to enlighten the representatives and present new tactics in which they can help the victims. Thus, Von der Leyen's thematic combination of blue, yellow, and white colors, formal wearing, and a grieving environment, all purposely inform and appeal to the officers through a myriad of ways that they can pursue their international humanitarian law.

On many occasions, Von der Leyen uses visual imagery on the audience to outline their disparate experiences with those of the victims, inciting accountability. She accounts in detail the real struggles, deaths, and sufferings that innocent people went through in the Israel-Hamas war, ranging from men, women, children, and families. For instance, she states, "The abandoned children's toys that no child would ever touch again. Hamas' terrorists slaughtered over 1,400 men, women, children, and babies in one day." By using childrens' abandoned toys and the slaughtered people as an element of tragedy, it serves as to not only emphasize the act of targeting young victims, but also depict the atrocious influence of war on innocent lives, spreading fear and alarm. This evokes a poignant response on the audience by reflecting on their own context with the abomination of human rights happening currently at the war. Generally, Von der Leyen effectively conveys her exigency by informing the factual death statistics and the description of these events, appealing through a bereaved tone.

Through the constant mentions of humanitarian aid, Von der Leyen also asserts her credibility as the President of EU Parliament through anecdotes confirmed by other leaders. To showcase, she claims, "I have visited Israel many times in my life." As seen previously, she

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establishes a close connection with Israel by signifying its importance on her personal life beyond professionalism. The audience can assimilate the value of Israel through the unquantifiable weight of “many”, hinting at Von der Leyen’s leveled fondness for the nation. Therefore, they can grasp the feeling of helplessness the situation reflects on her, speaking on behalf of residents who dwell in Israel. Subsequently, Von der Leyen transforms that taunting feeling into hope, “President Herzog... Prime Minister Netanyahu... all forces in the unity government, from families of the abducted. They all asked for solidarity and clear words... And this is the least we can do for the people of Israel.” In this example, she invokes various people in power who may be more recognized by European representatives, strengthening her argument on partaking in the mission of humanitarian aid, such as food, water, and shelter. Her exigency is effective because, not only does it inform about the torment placed on men, women, and children to allude to the audience’s own relatives, but also appeals to the speaker’s insightful and trustworthy character. By embracing the state of solidarity for Israel, Von der Leyen recalls instances of her involvement in Israel and interactions with other ambassadors through anecdotes.

To supplement Von der Leyen’s point, her exigency of supporting Israel predominates her speech through the manipulation of language and assertive tone. In this case, she applies this technique to guide the audience’s interpretation, clarifying who they must side with in the subject matter. Von der Leyen’s assertive tone can be heard from repeating “must”, “nothing”, and other lines containing absolute terms. She expressed, “But there is nothing inevitable in this [war]”, to blame human insensibility and foolishness, and by adding “[They] must be free to wear a kippah or a star of David in our streets... to light our cities with the candles of Chanukah in their windows,” she promotes inclusive communities to the streets of Europe, such as the Jewish

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people. By affirming the fact that war is not essentially instigated by human selfishness but by choice, Von der Leyen later proposes the celebration of cultural values and traditions to criminalize war. Thus, her exigency encourages the audience to support individuals regardless of their ideological and racial differences, which is empowered by her urgent “must”, establishing a stronger sense of duty. Though informal, strong tones guide the audience into a reflective form of thinking while attracting their attention to the contextual implications behind the social responsibility to embrace traditions outside of theirs. This authorial choice effectively appeals to the audience by compromising for a good cause, exhorting respectful behavior, and informing the historical significance of welcoming Jewish people to their land. Seemingly, Von der Leyen’s use of language through an assertive tone urges the audience to accept distinctive cultural values and norms given the context of the victims, ultimately achieving international peace.

Other than criminalizing war, Von der Leyen utilizes parallelism to encourage a call-to-action from the audience. Through direct phrases such as “We first have to listen, if we want to be listened to,” the grammatical wordplay represents a reciprocal relationship between the audience and the victims. Therefore, depending on the audience’s context and personal connection to Israel, they might feel in favor, entitled, or in opposition to the argument. Based on Lane (37), the speaker has to take into consideration that audience members may lack a motive to assimilate their message if they do not have some connection, or are not actively following along the speech. Meaning, if they do not have the voluntariness, contextual relevance, or fundamental knowledge towards the topic, their attention may veer off from the speaker's main mode of persuasion. Therefore, speakers are responsible for using coherent language, and understanding that their audience is multi-varied, which is why Von der Leyen states a slightly paradoxical wordplay that can easily be understood regardless of age, sex, race, and among other

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categories. Her exigency to treat Jewish people and victims humanly is effective in recalling the Arab-Israeli conflict, inducing a sense of sympathy and duty to those that may have opposed it first handedly. Hence, Von der Leyen remarkably uses affirmative tone and parallelism to outline both the settlement of Jewish people in 1949 and the audience's support in the present day.

In the end, Von der Leyen presented color code, visual imagery, anecdote, manipulation of language, tone, and parallelism, to follow the European's Parliament's international humanitarian law, and hold the audience accountable to receiving affected communities. As a speaker, she effectively rationalized why her audience should act in correspondence with their humanitarian aid mission given the context of Israel's past wars, Von der Leyen's alibi, the victims, and the audience's position itself.

President Joe Biden's Speech

On October 10, 2023, President Joe Biden of the United States of America delivered remarks on the Israel-Hamas attacks from the White House three days after the global outrage, accompanied by Vice President Kamala Harris and Secretary of State Antony Blinken. Joe Biden is the 46th President of the United States of America leaning on the Democratic Party, who is recognized for following a progressive stance in women's rights, Violence Against Women Act (VAWA), and gun violence prevention efforts by creating The Office of Gun Violence Prevention. Moreover, on October 9, 2023, Biden and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu spoke about Palestine's statehood, with the US president proposing him to cease ground assault on the Palestinian Gaza Strip and on other prolonged military attacks (Holland, Spetalnick). Because of Biden's left-leaning perspective on the Israel-Hamas war and Netanyahu's "uncomfortable" alliance, Biden held the speech to illustrate the overlooked,

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harrowing violence which the U.S. has historically attempted to reduce with its trading partner.

Thereafter, Biden declares his distastefulness towards the anti-semitic atrocities, giving priority to the American hostage recovery efforts while standing in solidarity with Israel.

Joe Biden gave a speech inside the White House's State Dining Room at 2:24 P.M. EDT, wearing his usual presidential attire. The audience consisted of 140 guests inside the Executive Residence of the White House, ranging from notable prime ministers, presidents, politicians, and representatives. Accompanied by two of Biden's officers, they all simultaneously enter the room with stern facial expressions so as to give their condolences and pay respect to the issue. According to Connor (1), non-verbal methods such as dress code, appearance, types of gestures; verbal methods such as tone of voice, vocabulary, delivery, and speed, are favorable tools that contribute to the emotional appeal of the speaker. Biden effectively communicates the Israel-Hamas ordeal by centralizing his eyes to a firm point into the audience. In other words, Biden's speech is evocative and personal because it was rehearsed beforehand without explicit visual aid. It constructs a natural flow to the discussion between him and his audience, establishing a sensational, coherent, transfer of ideas that pertain to the issue. Relevantly, Biden makes regular pauses to gain control of his speech, punctuate certain key points in the subject matter, and allow the audience to understand his argument. At times, he aligns his convictions through a rhythmic body language, such as opening his hands, widening his eyes, and raising his eyebrows. This way, the audience is not distracted by other erratic movements that may interrupt the speech. Another essential tool is how he maintains eye-contact with the public to acknowledge their responses, strengthening the personal connection with each individual, and assuring that they are regarded by continuing with his thread of thought. By rehearsing a speech with mental guide notes, balancing eye-contact, and body signaling, Biden's exigency effectively

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informs and appeals to the audience through auditory engagement and factual set of events in regards to the war.

As a major concern, Biden establishes a sense of patriotism through the use of pathos over the United States of America, particularly on saving American lives before Palestinians'. Patriotic feelings is a form of pathos that speakers apply to justify why a country's beliefs should be followed for the greater good of its citizens. After referring to the Hamas group and anti-semitics, Biden informs, "At least 14 American citizens killed." This demographic isolation proposes the idea that the U.S.'s priority over its civilians' safety comes before immigrants and from the Eastern Hemisphere. While Biden does consecutively refine the national exigency of protecting American citizens, he also promotes the American Dream. His statement, "That's what America stands for", recalls America's prideful history by associating it as an aspirational, inclusive, and goodwill nation. This way, audiences have a purpose to support their nation's efforts on aiding Israel, from losing American citizens like Pearl Harbor, and having experienced similar widespread tragedies in the past. Biden's exigency is effective because it appeals to the audience by portraying the U.S. as a savior for the recovery efforts, and informing their nation's historical losses and involvement with Israel.

Next, Biden integrates allusion to anti-semitic based and hostile wars that have indirectly marked America's socio-political system. This includes both U.S. neutrality and formation of alliances, particularly during World War II in 1939, the Cold War in 1947, and the Arab-Israeli war in 1948. Specifically, Biden highlights, "You know these traumas never go away... Sadly, it's not new". Particularly, he associates the historical burden on the country that radically transformed prejudices and systematic discrimination. While this allusion hints at a view towards the future of Israel, Biden contextually chose to dedicate this line to a group within

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the audience that may have experienced the changes in American society. Biden reminds the audience of their patriotism through pathos and allusions to ascertain a sympathetic connection between America's upbringings and Israel's current conflict. For that reason, Biden effectively communicates his exigency by making references to the changes in U.S. technology, civil rights, and economic prosperity.

Another detail is how Biden's use of language is based on its literal meaning when narrating events, called denotation. That being said, Biden expresses his opinions about the actions of the militant group of Hamas with a neutral and consistent baseline to underline a non-negotiable idea and feeling. Biden states, "It's abhorrent... This is terrorism." In this line, Biden allows the audience to recognize that the war is not excusable through "This is terrorism", and is the product of despicable human behavior by mentioning that "It's abhorrent". In return, the audience understands that the actions incurring are unredeemable and should be frowned upon, thus encouraging American citizens to antagonize Hamas. Furthermore, sometimes the literal term of his messages sound blunt particularly to shed light on issues that may not be obvious if used metaphorically. He vividly describes, "Parents butchered using their bodies to try to protect their children... Women raped, assaulted, paraded as trophies." The literal events that Biden hitherto provides, tackles numerous forms of violence imposed on parents, children, women, and other individuals. Biden's purpose is to realistically depict the experiences that Israelis and Palestinians went through to stimulate a horrified emotional appeal, which could not be solely illustrated through words like "killed" and "abused", but "butchered" and "raped". Through the use of graphic imagery, Biden fights against any ignorance and unawareness present in individuals, given their context and limited exposure to violence. In that sense, Biden's

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exigency to recognize the objective truth behind the war is effective because it informs the otherwise censored terrorism, causing a horrified or uncomfortable appeal.

On a similar note, Biden employs repetition to make his statement as memorable as possible. To illustrate, he asserts twice a political, declarative slogan, “We stand with Israel,” to embed the resolve of supporting Israel through their suffering, switching to an imperative tone. He uses the first-person plural pronoun “we” to collectively regard all listeners in the fulfillment of this pact. Coming from the President himself, the audience may feel swayed to listen to their commitment to Israel as it merges with a proud sense of duty, signifying the nation’s authenticity for pledging for a virtuous outcome. Then, by iterating the term “Don’t”, he hinders potentially ill-intended people from exploiting Israel’s vulnerable position, further buttressing the idea that being aware of war makes one accountable on helping to soothe the situation in their own available ways, like in social media, for example. In response, the audience may be pressured to protect Israel through other means of dissemination, strengthening Biden’s exigency and active duty as a figure of authority. Biden claims that American citizens are accountable for misrepresenting or placing victims at a disadvantage through denotation and repetition, causing a moral impetus to make the right decisions at the other side of the world.

Most of the time, Biden carried his speech with unaided visuals, patriotism as pathos, allusion, denotation, and repetition, to appeal to his duty as a liberal figure. While Biden exerts American patriotism and historical truthfulness regarding the Israel-Hamas war, he effectively invited the audience to be considerate of situations that they are unfamiliar with to share grievances and pay respect to Israel.

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Conclusion

Throughout the essay, the research question, *How do Ursula von der Leyen and Joe Biden use exigency to effectively inform and appeal to the audience about the Israel-Hamas War?*, was centered on the responses of Ursula Von der Leyen and Joe Biden's viewpoints standing in solidarity with Israel, taking into account the contextual situation of the Middle East conflict, Jewish victims, and the audience's multi-varied connections. Both speakers employed a variation of figurative tools through visual and linguistic mediums on the subject matter, to effectively communicate factual data and prompt emotions of guilt, responsibility, horror, and reflection. While the leaders were located in different regions, their exigencies, executive power, and national duty focused on swaying their respective target audience to a course of action given the available means to do so. Von der Leyen majorly highlighted the European Parliament's efforts to continue to send humanitarian aid to Israel, while Biden introduced the recovery mission of American lives as an appealing method and testament to their contributions. Regardless of their tactics, their objectives were focused on amassing support and recognition from the audience, ultimately sympathizing with Israel because of historically significant events. Even though a sector of the speech may be effective, such as delivering information, it does not guarantee a strong moral impetus if the values behind the speech defies that of the audience, and if the emotional appeal fails to incorporate their contextual background. When presenting a speech, politicians refer to a set of rhetoric rules as a way to inform and appeal to an audience, ensuring that their credibility and exigency effectively induce the audience to achieve a common ground.

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Appendix

President Ursula von der Leyen's Speech

European Commission

EN

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Aid, Development cooperation, Fundamental rights

European Neighbourhood Policy and Enlargement Negotiations (DG NEAR)

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Speech by President von der Leyen at the EP Plenary debate on the despicable terrorist attacks by Hamas against Israel, Israel's right to defend itself in line with humanitarian and international law and the humanitarian situation in Gaza

NEWS ARTICLE | 19 October 2023 | Directorate-General for Neighbourhood and Enlargement Negotiations | 6 min read

Speech by President von der Leyen at the EP Plenary debate on the despicable terrorist attacks by Hamas against Israel, Israel's right to defend itself in line with humanitarian and international law and the humanitarian situation in Gaza



Madam President, dear Roberta,

High Representative, Josep,

Minister Albares,

Hamas' terror has plunged Israel and Palestine into a new spiral of violence. Last night, a senseless tragedy has shocked us all. A hospital in Gaza – sheltering hundreds of wounded people – was turned into a hell of fire. The scenes from Al-Ahli hospital are horrifying and distressing. There is no excuse for hitting a hospital full of civilians. All facts need to be established, and those responsible must be held accountable.

In this tragic hour, we must all redouble our efforts to protect civilians from the fury of this war. And let me express my condolences to the families of the victims of the terrorist attacks in Brussels and Arras. Tragically, we see that terror is resurfacing again. It is also terror that brings us here to this debate. The heinous terror attacks of Hamas on Israel. What we have seen in the Kfar Azza kibbutz is pure evil. The blood, witness of horror, the burned houses, the abandoned children's toys that no child would ever touch again. Hamas' terrorists slaughtered over 1,400 men, women, children and babies in one day. For one single reason, because they were Jews, just living in the State of Israel with the explicit goal to eradicate Jewish life.

Israel has the right to self-defence, in line with international law. Hamas are terrorists. And the Palestinian people are also suffering from that terror. And we have to support them. And there is no contradiction in standing in solidarity with Israel and acting on the humanitarian needs of the Palestinian people. I have visited Israel many times in my life. But this time, I saw a nation that is shocked to the core. I was struck to hear the same request from all the people I spoke to. From President Herzog, from Prime Minister Netanyahu, all forces in the unity government, from families of the abducted. They all asked for solidarity and clear words. And this is the least we can do for the people of Israel. This horror calls for a united response from us. As human beings, as defenders of a free world, as citizens of Europe where hate, terror and racism have no place. Europe stands with Israel in this dark moment.

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This is the essential starting point. And I believe it was important to pass this message of solidarity in person, in Israel, just days after the Hamas attack. Only if we acknowledge Israel's pain, and its right to defend itself, will we have the credibility to say that Israel should react as a democracy, in line with international humanitarian law. And that it is crucial to protect civilian lives, even and especially in the middle of a war.

We first have to listen, if we want to be listened to. And indeed, during my visit, I discussed Israel's efforts to protect civilian lives. There can be no hesitation on our side: Europe will always be on the side of humanity and of human rights.

Allow me to update you on our work to address this dramatic situation, and the broader crisis that Hamas has unleashed.

Let me begin with the humanitarian situation, which is getting worse by the hour. Humanitarian aid must urgently reach Palestinians. This is why we have decided to immediately triple our humanitarian aid to civilians in Gaza. And we have launched an EU Humanitarian Air Bridge to Egypt, to bring life-saving supplies to humanitarian organisations on the ground in Gaza. The first two flights are taking place already this week, carrying humanitarian cargo from UNICEF. We have deployed our staff, and we are working with UN agencies to ensure that this aid can reach those in need. The European Union has always been the largest international donor to Palestine. And this will not change. But as the situation on the ground evolves, it is also essential that we urgently and carefully review our financial assistance for Palestine. EU funding has never gone to Hamas or any terrorist entity. And it never will. What Hamas has done has nothing to do with the legitimate aspirations of the Palestinian people. So, it was good to hear President Abbas' clear words that came out on Sunday evening.

My second point is about the regional situation. Hamas' actions have major geopolitical implications. We know that they risk affecting the historic rapprochement between Israel and the Arab countries. But there is nothing inevitable in this. Instability can be contained. Dialogue between Israel and its neighbours can and must continue. So this time of war must also be a time of unrelenting diplomacy. A moment to engage even more closely with Israel and with other countries in the region. I have been recently talking to several Arab leaders, including the King of Jordan, the President of the UAE, as well as the President of Egypt. All were very clear about the importance of our EU funding. And the European Union with its massive funding, we are the largest donor, has not only leverage but also has a stake in it.

Thirdly, we are seeing a rise in anti-Semitic incidents, including here in Europe. Synagogues have been vandalised. Hate speech and fake news are spreading at worrying speed. And this is something that we simply cannot accept. It is our shared responsibility to make sure that our dark past does not return. We have to protect Jewish life in Europe.

In these years, we have put the fight against anti-Semitism and all hate crimes at the heart of our action. Thanks to our collective work on the Digital Services Act, we now have laws to take down illegal content online and contain the spread of disinformation. And we are now using them for the first time ever. We have already launched an investigation in relation to X, formerly known as Twitter. They must comply with the obligation to counter the spread of terrorist propaganda and hate speech. Because in Europe, there is no place, and zero tolerance for hate, whether online or in our streets.

We have also stepped up our work to ensure the physical security of Jewish communities. We have already increased EU funding for the protection of places of worship – such as synagogues. And at the beginning of the mandate, we proposed to add hate crimes and hate speech to the list of EU crimes, that must be sanctioned all across our Union. Our proposal is still blocked by some Member States. But it cannot wait any longer. It is time now for Member States to act and move on.

Europe's history is a history of diversity. Jewish values have shaped our common European values. Among others, Jewish culture has for centuries enriched our common European culture. And this must continue to be the case. European Jews must be free to wear a kippah or a star of David in our streets. And to light our cities with the candles of Chanukah in their windows. And every European must be free from fear. We must make good on Europe's promise to be united in diversity to be a safe place for all Europeans.

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diversity to be a safe place for all Europeans.

Honourable Members,

This is the moment for all of us to come together to join forces against terror in all its forms. And to do what is right. I will now go back to Brussels to join a commemoration ceremony for the victims of the recent terror attack in Brussels.

I thank you for your attention.

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President Joe Biden's Speech

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OCTOBER 20, 2023

Remarks by President Biden on the United States' Response to Hamas's Terrorist Attacks Against Israel and Russia's Ongoing Brutal War Against Ukraine

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8:02 P.M. EDT

THE PRESIDENT: Good evening, my fellow Americans. We're facing an inflection point in history — one of those moments where the decisions we make today are going to determine the future for decades to come. That's what I'd like to talk with you about tonight.

You know, earlier this morning, I returned from Israel. They tell me I'm the first American president to travel there during a war.

I met with the Prime Minister and members of his cabinet. And most movingly, I met with Israelis who had personally lived through horrific horror of the attack by Hamas on the 7th of October.

More than 1,300 people slaughtered in Israel, including at least 32 American citizens. Scores of innocents — from infants to elderly grandparents, Israelis, Americans — taken hostage.

As I told the families of Americans being held captive by Hamas, we're pursuing every avenue to bring their loved ones home. As President, there is no higher priority for me than the safety of Americans held hostage.

The terrorist group Hamas unleashed pure, unadulterated evil in the world. But sadly, the Jewish people know, perhaps better than anyone, that there is no limit to the depravity of people when they want to inflict pain on others.

In Israel, I saw a people who are strong, determined, resilient, and also angry, in shock, and in deep, deep pain.

I also spoke with President Abbas of the Palestinian Authority and reiterated that the United States remains committed to the Palestinian people's right to dignity and to self-determination. The actions of Hamas terrorists don't take

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that right away.

Like so many other, I am heartbroken by the tragic loss of Palestinian life, including the explosion at a hospital in Gaza — which was not done by the Israelis.

We mourn every innocent life lost. We can't ignore the humanity of innocent Palestinians who only want to live in peace and have an opportunity.

You know, the assault on Israel echoes nearly 20 months of war, tragedy, and brutality inflicted on the people of Ukraine — people that were very badly hurt since Putin launched his all-out invasion.

We've have not forgotten the mass graves, the bodies found bearing signs of torture, rape used as a weapon by the Russians, and thousands and thousands of Ukrainian children forcibly taken into Russia, stolen from their parents. It's sick.

Hamas and Putin represent different threats, but they share this in common: They both want to completely annihilate a neighboring democracy — completely annihilate it.

Hamas — its stated purpose for existing is the destruction of the State of Israel and the murder of Jewish people.

Hamas does not represent the Palestinian people. Hamas uses Palestinian civilians as human shields, and innocent Palestinian families are suffering greatly because of them.

Meanwhile, Putin denies Ukraine has or ever had real statehood. He claims the Soviet Union created Ukraine. And just two weeks ago, he told the world that if the United States and our allies withdraw — and if the United States withdraw, our allies will as well — military support for Ukraine, it would have, quote, “a week left to live.” But we're not withdrawing.

I know these conflicts can seem far away. And it's natural to ask: Why does this matter to America?

So let me share with you why making sure Israel and Ukraine succeed is vital for America's national security. You know, history has taught us that when terrorists don't pay a price for their terror, when dictators don't pay a price for their aggression, they cause more chaos and death and more destruction. They keep going, and the cost and the threats to America and to the world keep rising.

So, if we don't stop Putin's appetite for power and control in Ukraine, he won't limit himself just to Ukraine. He's — Putin has already threatened to “remind” — quote, “remind” Poland that their western land was a gift from Russia.

One of his top advisors, a former president of Russia, has called Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania Russia's “Baltic provinces.” These are all NATO Allies.

For 75 years, NATO has kept peace in Europe and has been the cornerstone of

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American security. And if Putin attacks a NATO Ally, we will defend every inch of NATO which the treaty requires and calls for.

We will have something that we do not seek — make it clear: we do not seek — we do not seek to have American troops fighting in Russia or fighting against Russia.

Beyond Europe, we know that our allies and, maybe most importantly, our adversaries and competitors are watching. They're watching our response in Ukraine as well.

And if we walk away and let Putin erase Ukraine's independence, would-be aggressors around the world would be emboldened to try the same. The risk of conflict and chaos could spread in other parts of the world — in the Indo-Pacific, in the Middle East — especially in the Middle East.

Iran is — is supporting Russia's U- — in Ukraine, and it's supporting Hamas and other terrorist groups in the region. And we'll continue to hold them accountable, I might add.

The United States and our partners across the region are working to build a better future for the Middle East, one where the Middle East is more stable, better connected to its neighbors, and — through innovative projects like the India-Middle East-Europe rail corridor that I announced this year at the summit of the world's biggest economies. More predictable markets, more employment, less rage, less grievances, less war when connected. It benefits the people — it would benefit the people of the Middle East, and it would benefit us.

American leadership is what holds the world together. American alliances are what keep us, America, safe. American values are what make us a partner that other nations want to work with. To put all that at risk if we walk away from Ukraine, if we turn our backs on Israel, it's just not worth it.

That's why, tomorrow, I'm going to send to Congress an urgent budget request to fund America's national security needs, to support our critical partners, including Israel and Ukraine.

It's a smart investment that's going to pay dividends for American security for generations, help us keep American troops out of harm's way, help us build a world that is safer, more peaceful, and more prosperous for our children and grandchildren.

In Israel, we must make sure that they have what they need to protect their people today and always.

The security package I'm sending to Congress and asking Congress to do is an unprecedented commitment to Israel's security that will sharpen Israel's qualitative military edge, which we've committed to — the qualitative military edge.

We're going to make sure Iron Dome continues to guard the skies over Israel. We're going to make sure other hostile actors in the region know that Israel is

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stronger than ever and prevent this conflict from spreading.

Look, at the same time, President [Prime Minister] Netanyahu and I discussed again yesterday the critical need for Israel to operate by the laws of war. That means protecting civilians in combat as best as they can. The people of Gaza urgently need food, water, and medicine.

Yesterday, in discussions with the leaders of Israel and Egypt, I secured an agreement for the first shipment of humanitarian assistance from the United Nations to Palestinian civilians in Gaza.

If Hamas does not divert or steal this shipment — these shipments, we're going to provide an opening for sustained delivery of lifesaving humanitarian assistance for the Palestinians.

And as I said in Israel: As hard as it is, we cannot give up on peace. We cannot give up on a two-state solution.

Israel and Palestinians equally deserve to live in safety, dignity, and peace.

You know, and here at home, we have to be honest with ourselves. In recent years, too much hate has been given too much oxygen, fueling racism, a rise in antisemitism and ~~Islamophobia~~ [Islamophobia] right here in America.

It's also intensified in the wake of recent events that led to the horrific threats and attacks that both shock us and break our hearts.

On October 7th, terror attacks have triggered deep scars and terrible memories in the Jewish community.

Today, Jewish families worried about being targeted in school, wearing symbols of their faith walking down the street, or going out about their daily lives.

You know, I know many of you in the Muslim American community or the Arab American community, the Palestinian American community, and so many others are outraged and hurting, saying to yourselves, "Here we go again," with Islamophobia and distrust we saw after 9/11.

Just last week, a mother was brutally stabbed, a little boy — here in the United States — a little boy who had just turned six years old was murdered in their home outside of Chicago.

His name was Wadea — Wadea — a proud American, a proud Palestinian American family.

We can't stand by and stand silent when this happens. We must, without equivocation, denounce antisemitism. We must also, without equivocation, denounce Islamophobia.

And to all of you hurting — those of you who are hurting, I want you to know: I see you. You belong. And I want to say this to you: You're all America. You're all America.

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This is in a moment where there's — you know, in moments like these, when fear and suspicion, anger and rage run hard, that we have to work harder than ever to hold on to the values that make us who we are.

We're a nation of religious freedom, freedom of expression. We all have a right to debate and disagree without fear of being targeted at schools or workplaces or in our communities.

And we must renounce violence and vitriol, see each other not as enemies but as — but as fellow Americans.

When I was in Israel yesterday, I said that when America experienced the hell of 9/11, we felt enraged as well. While we sought and got justice, we made mistakes. So, I cautioned the government of Israel not to be blinded by rage.

And here in America, let us not forget who we are. We reject all forms — all forms of hate, whether against Muslims, Jews, or anyone. That's what great nations do, and we are great nation.

On Ukraine, I'm asking Congress to make sure we can continue to send Ukraine the weapons they need to defend themselves and their country without interruption so Ukraine can stop Putin's brutality in Ukraine.

They are succeeding.

When Putin invaded Ukraine, he thought he would take Kyiv and all of Ukraine in a matter of days. Well, over a year later, Putin has failed, and he continues to fail. Kyiv still stands because of the bravery of the Ukrainian people.

Ukraine has regained more than 50 percent of the territory Russian troops once occupied, backed by a U.S.-led coalition of more than 50 countries around the world all doing its part to support Kyiv.

What would happen if we walked away? We are the essential nation.

Meanwhile, Putin has turned to Iran and North Korea to buy attack drones and ammunition to terrorize Ukrainian cities and people.

From the outset, I have said I will not send American troops to fight in Ukraine.

All Ukraine is asking for is help — for the weapons, munitions, the capacity, the capability to push invading Russian forces off their land, and the air defense systems to shoot down Russian missiles before they destroy Ukrainian cities.

And let me be clear about something: We send Ukraine equipment sitting in our stockpiles. And when we use the money allocated by Congress, we use it to replenish our own stores — our own stockpiles with new equipment — equipment that defe- — that defends America and is made in America: Patriot missiles for air defense batteries made in Arizona; artillery shells manufactured in 12 states across the country — in Pennsylvania, Ohio, Texas;

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and so much more.

You know, just as in World War Two, today, patriotic American workers are building the arsenal of democracy and serving the cause of freedom.

Let me close with this. Earlier this year, I boarded Air Force One for a secret flight to Poland. There, I boarded a train with blacked-out windows for a 10-hour ride each way to Kyiv to stand with the people of Ukraine ahead of the one-year anniversary of their brave fight against Putin.

I'm told I was the first American [president] to enter a warzone not controlled by the United States military since President Lincoln.

With me was just a small group of security personnel and a few advisors.

But when I exited that train and met Zelenskyy — President Zelenskyy, I didn't feel alone. I was bringing with me the idea of America, the promise of America to the people who are today fighting for the same things we fought for 250 years ago: freedom, independence, self-determination.

And as I walked through Kyiv with President Zelenskyy, with air raid sirens sounding in the distance, I felt something I've always believed more strongly than ever before: America is a beacon to the world still. Still.

We are, as my friend Madeleine Albright said, "the indispensable nation."

Tonight, there are innocent people all over the world who hope because of us, who believe in a better life because of us, who are desperate not be forgotten be- — by us, and who are waiting for us.

But time is of the essence.

I know we have our divisions at home. We have to get past them. We can't let petty, partisan, angry politics get in the way of our responsibilities as a great nation.

We cannot and will not let terrorists like Hamas and tyrants like Putin win. I refuse to let that happen.

In moments like these, we have to remind — we have to remember who we are. We are the United States of America — the United States of America. And there is nothing — nothing beyond our capacity if we do it together.

My fellow Americans, thank you for your time.

May God bless you all. And may God protect our troops.

8:17 P.M. EDT

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